Masterkey

The Thousand Oaks

Seller's Prep Checklist

Your complete guide to selling your home in the Conejo Valley for top dollar.

$1.03M	29-42	99%	68%
Median Price Thousand Oaks	Avg Days on Market	Sale-to-List Ratio	Inventory Growth YoY

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Why Sell Now?

The Conejo Valley real estate market in 2026 presents a unique window for homeowners considering a sale. While the market has shifted from the extreme seller's conditions of 2021-2022, the fundamentals remain strong for well-prepared sellers who price correctly and present their homes at their best.

A Balanced Market Still Favors Prepared Sellers

Active listings are up 68% year-over-year in the Conejo Valley (492 vs. 292 in Q2 2025), and months of inventory has increased from 1.9 to 3.0 months. While this means buyers have more choices, it's still well below the 6+ months that would signal a true buyer's market. Sellers who invest in presentation and price strategically are still achieving strong results.

Sources: Avantone Real Estate Q2 2025 Market Update; Realtor.com Conejo Valley data

Equity Gains Are Real

Conejo Valley home values have appreciated significantly over the past five years. The median sold price reached $1,200,000 in Q2 2025, up 2% year-over-year, while the average sold price hit $1,505,048, up 5% YoY. If you purchased your home before 2020, you're likely sitting on substantial equity gains that can fund your next move, retirement, or investment goals.

Source: Pacific Home Group; Avantone Real Estate Q2 2025 data

$1.2M	+5%	3.0 Mo	162
Median Sold Conejo Valley	Avg Price Growth YoY	Months of Inventory	Luxury Sales $1.5M+ (Q2)

The Luxury Segment Is Thriving

If you own a home valued at $1.5 million or above, the news is even better. In Q2 2025, 162 homes sold above $1.5M in the Conejo Valley, a 15% increase year-over-year, with total dollar volume reaching $746.5 million (+14% YoY). Affluent buyers continue to seek the valley's combination of top schools, outdoor lifestyle, and relative value compared to LA's Westside.

Source: Avantone Real Estate Q2 2025 Luxury Market Report

Demand Remains Solid Despite Inventory Growth

The sale-to-list price ratio remains at 98-99%, meaning homes are selling very close to their asking prices. While 75% of listings have seen at least one price reduction, that statistic reflects overpricing rather than weak demand. Homes that are priced correctly from day one and well-presented continue to sell within 29-42 days on average.

MasterKey Insight

The best time to sell is when your personal circumstances align with a healthy market. In 2026, you have a market where demand is still solid, equity is strong, and serious buyers are actively searching. Don't wait for 'perfect' conditions that may never come. The key is preparation and pricing.

Preparing Your Home

First impressions drive offers. In a market where buyers have more choices, the homes that are clean, decluttered, and professionally presented command the highest prices and sell the fastest. Here's your preparation checklist.

1. Declutter and Depersonalize

Remove personal photos, excess furniture, and anything that prevents buyers from envisioning themselves in the space. Consider renting a storage unit for items you want to keep but that crowd the home. Buyers need to see open, airy rooms, not your personal museum.

2. Deep Clean Everything

Hire a professional cleaning crew for a top-to-bottom deep clean. This includes carpets, windows (inside and out), grout, baseboards, and appliances. Budget $500-$1,000. A spotless home signals to buyers that the property has been well-maintained.

3. Make Strategic Repairs

Address the items that will show up on a buyer's inspection and erode confidence: leaky faucets, cracked tiles, peeling paint, sticking doors, broken fixtures. Budget $2,000-$5,000 for minor repairs. A pre-listing inspection ($400-$600) can identify issues before they become negotiation leverage for the buyer.

4. Stage for Maximum Impact

Professional staging is one of the highest-ROI investments a seller can make. According to RESA (Real Estate Staging Association), staged homes in 2025 sold for an average of $56,000-$101,931 above list price, with an average staging investment of just $3,588-$4,387. That translates to an average ROI of 2,334-4,415%.

Source: RESA Q1-Q3 2025 Market Statistics

$3,588	$56K+	2,334%	12 Days
Avg Staging Investment	Avg Over List Price	Average Staging ROI	Avg Days on Market

RESA Q1 2025 data. Staged homes vs. market average.

5. Boost Curb Appeal

The exterior is the first thing buyers see, both online and in person. Fresh mulch, trimmed hedges, a power-washed driveway, a painted front door, and updated house numbers can transform a home's first impression. Budget $500-$2,000 for landscaping and exterior touch-ups.

Pro Tip: The $14,000 That Pays for Itself

Total estimated prep costs (inspection + staging + repairs + cleaning + landscaping) run approximately $14,000 for a typical Conejo Valley home. With staged homes selling for $56K-$101K above list on average, this investment pays for itself many times over. Don't skip it.

Pricing Strategy

Pricing is the single most important decision you'll make when selling your home. Price too high and you'll sit on the market; price too low and you leave money on the table. Here's how to get it right.

Start with a Comparative Market Analysis (CMA)

A CMA compares your home to similar properties that have recently sold, are currently listed, and have expired (failed to sell) in your area. Your MasterKey agent will prepare a detailed CMA that accounts for square footage, lot size, condition, upgrades, and micro-location factors. This is the foundation of your pricing strategy, not Zillow's Zestimate.

Pricing Psychology: The Science of Attraction

Buyers search in price brackets. A home listed at $1,050,000 appears in searches up to $1.1M, but a home at $1,100,000 may only show up in $1.1M-$1.2M searches, cutting you off from a significant pool of buyers. Price just below key thresholds to maximize visibility.

Under $999K captures all buyers searching 'under $1 million'

$1,049,000 vs. $1,050,000 can make a psychological difference

Round numbers ($1,000,000) often feel arbitrary; precise numbers ($998,500) signal data-driven pricing

The Danger of Overpricing

In the current Conejo Valley market, 75% of listings have experienced at least one price reduction. Overpriced homes don't just sit on the market; they actively lose value. Here's why:

Stale listing syndrome. The longer a home sits, the more buyers assume something is wrong with it. Homes that have been listed for 60+ days attract lowball offers.

Missed buyer momentum. The first 2-3 weeks generate the most activity. If you're overpriced during that window, you've missed the buyers most likely to pay top dollar.

Appraisal risk. Even if a buyer agrees to an inflated price, the lender's appraisal may not support it, killing the deal or forcing a last-minute renegotiation.

Price reduction stigma. Multiple price reductions on the MLS signal desperation and invite further low offers. It's far better to price right from day one.

MasterKey Insight: Price It Right from Day One

Our data shows that homes priced within 3% of market value on day one sell faster and for more money than homes that start high and reduce. Your MasterKey agent's CMA uses current Conejo Valley comp data, not algorithms, to find the price that generates maximum interest and competitive offers.

Conejo Valley Price Benchmarks

Metric	Value	Context
Median Sold Price	**$1,200,000**	Conejo Valley Q2 2025
Price per Sq Ft	**~$518**	Valley-wide average
Sale-to-List Ratio	**98-99%**	Homes selling near ask
Avg Days on Market	**29-42 days**	Well-priced homes
Listings w/ Reductions	**75%**	Overpricing is common

Sources: Avantone Real Estate, Pacific Home Group, Realtor.com (Q2 2025 data)

Understanding Your Costs

Selling a home isn't free. Between agent commissions, closing costs, and prep expenses, you need to understand what you'll actually net from the sale. Here's a transparent breakdown based on a $1,030,000 Thousand Oaks home.

Agent Commissions

Since the NAR settlement in 2024, commission structures have become more transparent and negotiable. In Thousand Oaks, the average listing agent commission is 2.57% and the average buyer agent commission is 2.46%, for a total average of 5.03%. On a $1.03M home, that's approximately $51,800.

Source: Clever Real Estate; Conejo Valley market data

Closing Costs

California sellers typically pay approximately 2.73% of the sale price in closing costs. Here's what that includes:

Cost Item	Details	Estimated Cost
Escrow fees	Split 50/50 in SoCal	$2,000-$3,000
Title insurance (owner's)	Seller pays in SoCal	~$1,338
Transfer tax	0.11% of sale price	~$1,133
Natural hazard report	Required disclosure	~$100
Grant deed preparation	Legal document	~$100
Sub-escrow / messenger	Administrative fees	~$135
Recording fees	Ventura County	~$244

HOA docs & transfer	If applicable	~$350
Prorated property taxes	Variable	Varies

Source: Clever Real Estate; Conejo Valley Guy cost analysis

Net Proceeds Estimate

Here's a realistic estimate of what you'd walk away with on a $1,030,000 sale, assuming a $400,000 remaining mortgage balance:

Sale price	$1,030,000
Less: Agent commissions (5.5%)	-$56,650
Less: Closing costs (~2.7%)	-$27,810
Less: Mortgage payoff	-$400,000
Less: Prep costs (est.)	-$10,000
Estimated net proceeds	**~$535,540**

Pro Tip: Negotiate Your Commission

Since the NAR settlement, commissions are more negotiable than ever. Some listing agents offer tiered commission structures based on sale price thresholds. Others may reduce their rate for repeat clients or if you're also buying through them. Your MasterKey agent will provide a transparent fee structure upfront.

The Selling Timeline

From preparation to closing, here's the typical timeline for selling a home in the Conejo Valley. Most financed sales close in 30-45 days after accepting an offer; all-cash transactions can close in as little as 7-21 days.

1. **Prep Your Home**
   Declutter, deep clean, make repairs, stage, and boost curb appeal. Allow 2-4 weeks for thorough preparation. Schedule a pre-listing inspection to identify and fix issues proactively.

2. **List and Market**
   Your MasterKey agent launches professional photography, a 3D virtual tour, targeted digital ads, MLS syndication, and social media campaigns. The first 2-3 weeks are critical for maximum exposure.

3. **Show Your Home**
   Open houses, private showings, and broker tours generate interest. Keep the home in showing-ready condition at all times. Your agent will provide feedback after each showing.

4. **Review and Accept an Offer**
   Evaluate offers on price, contingencies, financing strength, and closing timeline. Your agent will negotiate terms and counteroffers on your behalf to maximize your net proceeds.

5. **Open Escrow**
   Once under contract, escrow is opened. The buyer deposits earnest money (typically 1-3% of the purchase price). Escrow holds all funds and documents until closing.

6. **Buyer Inspections and Appraisal**
   The buyer conducts a home inspection and the lender orders an appraisal. Be prepared for a request for repairs (credits or fixes). Your MasterKey agent will negotiate to protect your bottom line.

7. **Clear Contingencies and Close**
   The buyer removes contingencies (inspection, appraisal, loan). Final walkthrough is completed. You sign closing documents at the title company, and the deed is recorded with Ventura County.

8. **Move Out and Hand Over Keys**
   Per your agreement, you vacate the property (typically on closing day or with a rent-back arrangement). Congratulations, your home is sold!

Timeline Summary

Pre-listing prep: 2-4 weeks | Active marketing: 3-6 weeks (avg 29-42 days) | Escrow to close: 30-45 days (financed) or 7-21 days (cash). Total from prep to keys: ~3-4 months.

California Disclosure Checklist

California has some of the most comprehensive seller disclosure requirements in the country. Failing to disclose known issues can expose you to legal liability after the sale. Your MasterKey agent will guide you through every form, but here's what you need to know.

Sources: Clever Real Estate; Nolo.com California seller disclosure obligations

Required Disclosures

- **Transfer Disclosure Statement (TDS)** - Required by California law. Covers the condition of all major systems: structural, plumbing, electrical, HVAC, roof, foundation, and more. Complete this form honestly and thoroughly.
- **Natural Hazard Disclosure (NHD)** - A third-party report identifying whether your property is in a flood zone, fire hazard zone, earthquake fault zone, seismic hazard zone, or other natural hazard area. The Conejo Valley has wildfire-prone areas, so this is especially relevant.
- **Seller Property Questionnaire (SPQ)** - Covers neighborhood issues, noise, nuisances, insurance claims, code violations, lawsuits, and other matters that could affect the buyer's decision. Be thorough and honest.
- **Lead-Based Paint Disclosure** - Required by federal law for all homes built before 1978. You must disclose any known lead-based paint hazards and provide the EPA pamphlet.
- **Megan's Law Notice** - California requires a notice informing buyers about the state's sex offender database (Megan's Law). This is a standard form included in every transaction.
- **HOA Documents** - If your home is in a homeowners association, you must provide CC&Rs;, financial statements, meeting minutes, and any pending special assessments. Allow 2-3 weeks for your HOA to prepare these documents.

- **Mello-Roos / Special Tax Disclosure** - If your property is in a Community Facilities District (CFD), you must disclose the special tax. Some Thousand Oaks developments carry Mello-Roos assessments.
- **Additional California Requirements** - Deaths within the past 3 years on the property, environmental hazards (asbestos, mold, radon), structural modifications, boundary disputes, and any pending litigation affecting the property must all be disclosed.

Pro Tip: Prepare Disclosures Before Listing

Having your TDS, NHD, SPQ, and all other disclosures completed before you list your home leads to smoother transactions and fewer surprises during escrow. Buyers who receive disclosures upfront feel more confident, and you reduce the risk of deals falling apart over late-discovered issues.

Your Next Steps

You've got the knowledge. Now it's time to put it into action. MasterKey combines expert agents with technology to make selling your Conejo Valley home seamless, profitable, and stress-free.

1. **Book a Free Listing Consultation**
   No pressure, no obligation. We'll tour your home, discuss your goals and timeline, prepare a detailed CMA, and create a customized marketing plan to sell for top dollar.

2. **Get a Pre-Listing Home Assessment**
   Your MasterKey agent will identify the improvements that will yield the highest ROI, connect you with trusted local contractors and stagers, and help you prioritize your prep budget.

3. **Launch Your Listing with MasterKey**
   Professional photography, 3D tours, targeted digital marketing, and a dedicated listing specialist who knows the Conejo Valley inside and out. We handle everything so you can focus on your next chapter.

Meet Your MasterKey Team

MasterKey was built by two brothers who believe selling a home should be powered by technology and guided by expertise. Here's who you'll be working with.

Mark Mathias

Co-Founder / Principal Broker

With a background in SaaS sales leadership and product management, Mark brings a strategic, tech-forward approach to every real estate transaction. His goal: make selling your Conejo Valley home a seamless, profitable experience.

Michael Mathias

Co-Founder / CTO / Broker

Michael's expertise from leading ad-tech platforms for clients like Google and Nike powers MasterKey's technology-driven approach. He ensures every client gets cutting-edge marketing tools and maximum exposure.

Ready to Sell Your Home?

Visit www.usemasterkey.com/contact to schedule a free consultation or DM us **'SELLGUIDE'** on social media to connect with a Conejo Valley listing specialist.

This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute financial, legal, or real estate advice. Market data is sourced from Zillow, Realtor.com, Avantone Real Estate, Pacific Home Group, the California Association of Realtors, Clever Real Estate, RESA, and Conejo Valley Guy as of mid-2025 through early 2026 and is subject to change. Always consult with qualified professionals before making selling decisions. MasterKey is a licensed real estate brokerage in California.